THE VOICE SOJAM

Official Competition Handbook

Participation Requirements, Competition Rules, Voting Policies, and Code of Conduct

1. Eligibility

- Open to individuals ages 10 and above.
- Participants may compete as:
- Soloists
- Duets
- Groups/Choirs
- Participants must be a member or regular attendee of a local church.
- Participants must complete the official registration form before the registration deadline.
- Registration fees must be paid in full before participation is confirmed.
- Participants under the age of 18 are eligible to compete only with written consent from a parent or legal guardian.
- Participants may not change their competition category (Soloist, Duet, or Group/Choir) after the registration deadline unless approved by the Organizing Committee.
- A participant may compete in only one category during the competition season unless otherwise authorized by the Organizing Committee.

2. Parental Consent (Participants Under 18)

- All participants under the age of 18 must submit a completed and signed Parental/Guardian Consent Form before the registration deadline.
- A parent or legal guardian must authorize the participant's involvement in all competition activities, including rehearsals, performances, recordings, photography, livestreams, and travel associated with the competition, if applicable.
- Failure to provide the required consent form by the specified deadline may result in the participant's registration being deemed incomplete and ineligible for competition.

3. Music Requirements

- All performances must be Christian, Gospel, or Inspirational in nature.
- Songs containing inappropriate language or messages contrary to Christian values will not be accepted.
- Participants may perform:
- Original compositions
- Cover versions of approved Christian songs.
- Round-specific performance time limits apply; see Section 15.
- Lyrics must be submitted upon request by the Administrative Committee.
- The Administrative Committee reserves the right to reject any song deemed inconsistent with the mission and values of the competition.

4. Conduct and Appearance

- Participants must demonstrate Christian conduct, integrity, and sportsmanship throughout the competition.
- Appropriate and modest attire is required at all competition-related events.
- Contestants must maintain respectful conduct on social media and other public platforms throughout the competition.
- Any disrespectful behavior toward judges, organizers, volunteers, contestants, sponsors, or audience members may result in penalties or disqualification.
- Harassment, bullying, discrimination, or unsportsmanlike conduct will not be tolerated and may result in immediate disqualification.

5. Rehearsals and Attendance

- Contestants must attend all mandatory rehearsals, orientation meetings, and sound checks.
- Participants who arrive late without prior approval may forfeit their performance slot.
- Repeated absences from required competition activities may result in disqualification.
- Contestants are responsible for monitoring official competition communications and schedules.

6. Performance Rules

- Performances may be accompanied by:
- Live musicians
- Instrumental backing tracks
- Lip-syncing is strictly prohibited and will result in automatic disqualification.
- Contestants are responsible for providing any personal instruments or equipment not supplied by the organizers.
- Contestants must perform the song approved for their respective round unless prior authorization is granted.
- The Organizing Committee reserves the right to stop a performance that violates competition rules, exceeds the time limit, or contains material deemed inappropriate.
- Any attempt to influence judges, manipulate voting results, or gain an unfair advantage may result in immediate disqualification.
- Participants must comply with all stage, safety, and technical instructions provided by event staff.

7. Judging Criteria

Criteria	Weight
Vocal/Instrumental Ability	30%
Interpretation and Expression	20%
Stage Presence	20%
Musical Accuracy and Technique	15%
Spiritual Impact and Message	15%

Judges determine audition advancement; public votes decide later rounds (see Section 15).

8. Elimination and Advancement

- Contestants advance by judges at auditions and by public votes thereafter (see Section 15).
- Contestants eliminated during the competition may be invited to participate in special performances, showcases, or guest appearances at the discretion of the organizers.
- Organizers reserve the right to modify the competition structure, schedule, or advancement procedures if necessary to ensure fairness and the successful operation of the competition.

9. Media Release and Agreement

By registering for the competition, participants agree to:

- Follow all competition rules and regulations.
- Allow the organizers to photograph, record, livestream, and broadcast their performances and related activities.
- Permit the use of their name, image, likeness, and performance recordings for promotional, educational, publicity, and archival purposes without additional compensation.
- Accept that all decisions made by the judging panel and Organizing Committee are final and binding.

10. General Provisions

- The Organizing Committee reserves the right to interpret and enforce these rules.
- Failure to comply with any competition requirement may result in penalties or disqualification.
- The Organizing Committee reserves the right to amend these rules when necessary to ensure the integrity and success of the competition.
- Any matter not expressly covered by these rules shall be decided by the Organizing Committee, whose decision shall be final.
- Submission of a registration form constitutes acceptance of all competition rules, policies, and procedures.

11. Public Voting Rules

11.1 Voting Eligibility

- Public voting is open to all individuals who comply with the voting procedures established by the Organizing Committee.
- Votes may be cast only through official voting platforms authorized by The Voice SOJAM.
- The Organizing Committee reserves the right to verify the authenticity of all votes.

11.2 Voting Periods

- Voting periods will be announced prior to each round.
- Votes cast outside the designated voting period will not be counted.
- Official voting results will be certified before publication.

11.3 Prohibited Voting Activities

The following activities are strictly prohibited:

- Purchasing votes.
- Offering compensation in exchange for votes.
- Using bots, scripts, or automated systems.
- Creating fraudulent accounts.
- Manipulating voting systems.
- Coordinating fraudulent voting campaigns.
- Impersonating another individual for voting purposes.

11.4 Investigation of Voting Irregularities

- The Organizing Committee may review, audit, invalidate, or remove suspicious votes at any time.
- Contestants found to have participated in vote manipulation may face penalties including point deductions, loss of votes, suspension, or disqualification.
- Decisions regarding voting integrity shall be final.

11.5 Campaigning

- Contestants are encouraged to promote their participation respectfully.
- Campaigning may occur through social media, church announcements, personal networks, and community outreach.
- Campaigning must not involve harassment, intimidation, false statements, or attacks against other contestants.
- Contestants may not falsely claim endorsements, sponsorships, or affiliations.

12. Contestant Code of Conduct

12.1 Christian Character

Contestants shall demonstrate honesty, humility, integrity, and respect throughout the competition.

12.2 Respect for Others

Contestants shall treat judges, organizers, volunteers, sponsors, audience members, and fellow contestants with respect.

12.3 Social Media Conduct

Contestants shall refrain from cyberbullying, spreading misinformation, defamatory statements, or content inconsistent with Christian values.

12.4 Sportsmanship

Contestants agree to:

- Accept judges' decisions respectfully.
- Refrain from publicly disputing official results.
- Support fellow contestants.
- Contribute to a positive competition environment.

12.5 Disciplinary Measures

Violations may result in:

- Verbal warnings.
- Written warnings.
- Point deductions.
- Loss of votes.
- Suspension.
- Immediate disqualification.

12.6 Protection of the Competition's Reputation

- Contestants serve as representatives of The Voice SOJAM throughout the competition season.
- The Organizing Committee reserves the right to investigate conduct that may negatively affect the competition's integrity or reputation.
- Contestants whose actions bring disrepute to The Voice SOJAM, participating churches, sponsors, organizers, volunteers, or Christian values may be suspended or disqualified.
- This provision applies to conduct occurring both during and outside official competition activities, including social media activity and public appearances.
- Determinations made under this provision shall be final.

12.7 Commitment to Ministry

- Participants acknowledge that The Voice SOJAM is first and foremost a ministry initiative.
- Contestants agree to uphold the spiritual purpose of the competition.
- Christian character, fellowship, and service shall be valued above personal advancement.

13. Appeals and Final Authority

- Any concerns regarding competition procedures must be submitted in writing to the Organizing Committee.
- The Organizing Committee shall review the matter and issue a decision.
- All decisions of the Organizing Committee and judging panel are final and binding.

14. Competition Mission

The Voice SOJAM is more than a competition; it is a ministry dedicated to discovering, developing, and celebrating musical talents for the glory of God. Through music, participants are encouraged to inspire faith, promote Christian values, and use their gifts in service to God and their communities.

15. 2026 Season: Registration, Schedule & Round Rules

Updated October 12, 2026. These provisions govern the 2026 competition and replace any inconsistent prior schedule, performance time limit, advancement rule, or prize amount.

Registration and capacity. Registration opens October 17, 2026. A maximum of 25 contestants will be accepted across all categories. Each solo, duet, group, or choir entry counts as one contestant entry. Eligibility, required consent, payment verification, and approval requirements remain applicable.

Grand prize: $1,000 cash award, presented to the champion at the Grand Finale Gala on December 20, 2026.

Stage	Date (2026)	Maximum	Decision
Audition (one round)	November 21	7 minutes	Judges only
Round of 16	November 28	7 minutes	Public votes
Quarterfinals	December 5	7 minutes	Public votes
Semifinals	To be announced	5 minutes	Public votes
Grand Finale at the Gala	December 20	5 minutes	Public votes

15.1 Audition. There is one audition round only. Each performance is limited to 7 minutes. Exceeding 7 minutes may result in automatic elimination; the judges have the final word on whether elimination applies. The judges determine audition advancement using the judging criteria in Section 7. No public voting occurs at auditions.

15.2 Round of 16 and quarterfinals. Each performance is limited to 7 minutes. When the timer expires, the performance must stop immediately. Public votes determine advancement.

15.3 Semifinals and Grand Finale. Each performance is limited to 5 minutes. When the timer expires, the performance must stop immediately. Public votes select the finalists and the champion.

15.4 Voting and enforcement. Public voting begins at the Round of 16 and applies through the Grand Finale. Official voting windows, verification, vote certification, and anti-fraud policies in Section 11 remain in effect. The Organizing Committee retains authority to enforce eligibility, conduct, timing, and voting-integrity rules. The semifinal date will be announced through official competition communications.